

English Communication

Grammar, writing and speaking skills for college and
work

Sample study notes · Knowledge Dungeon

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Parts of Speech

Every English sentence is built from words, and every word does a particular job. Some name things, some describe them, some show action and some connect ideas. These jobs are called **parts of speech**. Knowing them is like knowing the pieces in chess: once you understand what each piece does, you can see how sentences work and fix them when they go wrong.

English has eight traditional parts of speech: nouns, pronouns, verbs, adjectives, adverbs, prepositions, conjunctions and interjections. Many grammar books also treat **articles** and **determiners** as a separate group.

Key idea: A word's part of speech depends on how it is used in a sentence, not on the word alone. "Light" is a noun in "Switch on the light", a verb in "Light the lamp", and an adjective in "a light bag".

Nouns

A **noun** names a person, place, thing, animal, idea or feeling: *teacher, Mumbai, laptop, tiger, freedom, happiness*.

Kinds of Nouns

- **Common nouns** name general things: *city, river, student*.

- **Proper nouns** name particular things and begin with a capital letter: *Delhi, the Ganga, Priya*.
- **Concrete nouns** name things you can see or touch: *book, chair*.
- **Abstract nouns** name ideas and qualities: *honesty, courage, knowledge*.
- **Collective nouns** name groups: *a team of players, a flock of birds, a bunch of keys*.
- **Countable nouns** can be counted and have plural forms: *one pen, two pens*.
- **Uncountable nouns** cannot be counted directly and have no plural: *water, information, advice, furniture, luggage*.

A very common mistake among Indian English speakers is pluralising uncountable nouns. We say "some advice", not "advices"; "a lot of information", not "informations"; "pieces of furniture", not "furnitures".

Plural Forms

- Most nouns add -s: *book, books*.
- Nouns ending in -s, -sh, -ch, -x add -es: *bus, buses; box, boxes*.
- Consonant + y becomes -ies: *city, cities*. (But vowel + y just adds -s: *day, days*.)

- Some nouns ending in *-f* or *-fe* change to *-ves*: *knife, knives; leaf, leaves*.
- Irregular plurals must be learnt: *child, children; man, men; tooth, teeth; mouse, mice; criterion, criteria; phenomenon, phenomena*.

Possessive Nouns

Add 's to show ownership: *Ravi's bike, the teacher's desk*. For plural nouns ending in s, add only an apostrophe: *the students' results*. For irregular plurals, add 's: *children's books*.

Pronouns

A **pronoun** replaces a noun so we do not repeat it. "Meera lost Meera's phone" becomes "Meera lost her phone".

Type	Examples	Use
Personal (subject)	I, you, he, she, it, we, they	Doer of the action: <i>She sings</i> .
Personal (object)	me, you, him, her, it, us, them	Receiver: <i>Call me</i> .
Possessive	mine, yours, his, hers, ours, theirs	Ownership: <i>The bag is mine</i> .
Reflexive	myself, yourself, himself, themselves	Action returns to the subject: <i>He hurt himself</i> .
Demonstrative	this, that, these, those	Pointing: <i>This is my seat</i> .
Interrogative	who, whom, whose, which, what	Questions: <i>Who called?</i>

Type	Examples	Use
Relative	who, whom, whose, which, that	Joining clauses: <i>The girl who won...</i>
Indefinite	someone, anyone, everyone, nobody, each	Non-specific: <i>Everyone agreed.</i>

Common Pronoun Errors

- **Subject vs object:** "Rahul and *I* went" (subject), but "The teacher praised Rahul and *me*" (object). Test by removing the other person: you would say "praised me", not "praised I".
- **Reflexive misuse:** "Please contact myself" is wrong. Use "Please contact me". Reflexives are only for actions that return to the subject, or for emphasis: "I made it *myself*."
- **Vague reference:** "Riya told Priya that she had passed." Who passed? Rewrite to make it clear.

Verbs

A **verb** expresses an action (*run, write, think*) or a state of being (*is, seem, belong*). Every complete sentence needs a verb.

- **Action verbs** show what someone does: *She writes code.*
- **Linking verbs** connect the subject to a description: *He is tired. The food smells good.* Common linking verbs are forms of *be*, and *seem, become, look, feel, taste*.
- **Auxiliary (helping) verbs** help the main verb form tenses, questions and negatives: *be, have, do*.

- **Modal verbs** express ability, permission, possibility or obligation: *can, could, may, might, must, shall, should, will, would*. They are always followed by the base form: "She *can speak*", not "She can speaks".

Verbs can be **transitive** (they need an object: "She *bought* a phone") or **intransitive** (no object: "The baby *slept*").

Verbs change form to show tense, which is the subject of Chapter 3.

Adjectives

An **adjective** describes a noun or pronoun: *a tall building, three students, an interesting book, She is happy*.

Degrees of Comparison

Positive	Comparative	Superlative
tall	taller	tallest
happy	happier	happiest
beautiful	more beautiful	most beautiful
good	better	best
bad	worse	worst
little	less	least

Use the comparative to compare two things ("Ravi is *taller than* Aman") and the superlative for three or more ("Ravi is *the tallest* in the class"). Never double them: "more better" and "most tallest" are wrong.

Order of Adjectives

When several adjectives describe one noun, native speakers follow an order: opinion, size, age, shape, colour, origin, material, purpose. So we say "a *lovely little old round red Indian wooden* box", not "a red wooden little lovely box". In practice, two or three adjectives are plenty.

Adverbs

An **adverb** modifies a verb, an adjective or another adverb. It answers *how, when, where, how often* or *to what extent*.

- How: *She spoke clearly.*
- When: *We will leave tomorrow.*
- Where: *Please sit here.*
- How often: *He always arrives late.*
- To what extent: *The test was very difficult.*

Many adverbs end in *-ly* (*quickly, carefully*), but not all (*fast, well, soon, often*). Remember: *good* is an adjective and *well* is the adverb. "She sings *well*", not "She sings *good*".

Prepositions

A **preposition** shows the relationship between a noun (or pronoun) and another word, often of place, time or direction: *in, on, at, under, between, through, during, since, for*.

In, On and At for Time and Place

	Time	Place
at	exact times: <i>at 5 pm, at noon</i>	specific points: <i>at the gate, at the bus stop</i>
on	days and dates: <i>on Monday, on 15 August</i>	surfaces and streets: <i>on the table, on MG Road</i>
in	months, years, seasons, parts of the day: <i>in May, in 2026, in the morning</i>	enclosed spaces, cities, countries: <i>in the room, in Pune</i>

Common Preposition Mistakes

- "Discuss *about* the plan" is wrong: *discuss* already means "talk about". Say "discuss the plan".
- "Married *with*" is wrong: say "married *to*".
- "Since two years" is wrong: *since* takes a starting point (*since 2024*), *for* takes a duration (*for two years*).
- "Return back" and "revert back" repeat the idea; say "return" or "reply".

Conjunctions

A **conjunction** joins words, phrases or clauses.

- **Coordinating conjunctions** join equal parts: *for, and, nor, but, or, yet, so* (remember **FANBOYS**). "I was tired, *but* I finished the assignment."

- **Subordinating conjunctions** join a dependent clause to a main clause: *because, although, if, when, since, unless, while, after, before*. "Although it rained, the match continued."
- **Correlative conjunctions** work in pairs: *either...or, neither...nor, both...and, not only...but also*.

Interjections

An **interjection** expresses sudden feeling: *Wow!, Oh!, Oops!, Hurray!* Interjections are common in speech and informal writing but should be avoided in formal writing.

Articles and Determiners

Articles are a small but tricky group: *a, an* and *the*. They are a kind of **determiner**, a word that introduces a noun and tells us which one or how many (*this, my, some, every, few*). Articles are covered in detail in Chapter 4.

Identifying Parts of Speech: A Worked Example

"Wow, the young engineer quickly solved the difficult problem because she understood it well."

- *Wow*: interjection
- *the*: article
- *young*: adjective

- *engineer*: noun
- *quickly*: adverb
- *solved*: verb
- *difficult*: adjective
- *problem*: noun
- *because*: subordinating conjunction
- *she*: pronoun
- *understood*: verb
- *it*: pronoun
- *well*: adverb

Summary

- Nouns name things; watch uncountable nouns like *advice*, *information* and *furniture*.
- Pronouns replace nouns; use subject forms (*I*, *he*) and object forms (*me*, *him*) correctly, and avoid misusing *myself*.
- Verbs show action or state; modals are followed by the base form.
- Adjectives describe nouns and have comparative and superlative forms; adverbs describe verbs, adjectives and other adverbs.

- Prepositions show relationships; learn *in*, *on* and *at*, and *since* versus *for*.
- Conjunctions join ideas; interjections express emotion.
- A word's part of speech depends on its use in the sentence.

Practice Questions

1. Identify the part of speech of each word: "The old man walked slowly across the busy road."
2. Correct the errors: "She gave me many useful advices and informations."
3. Fill in with *in*, *on* or *at*: "The exam is ____ Monday ____ 10 am ____ the main hall."
4. Write the comparative and superlative of *far*, *easy*, *careful* and *bad*.
5. Rewrite to remove the ambiguous pronoun: "When Arjun met Kabir, he was nervous."

Sentence Structure

Words become meaningful only when they are arranged into sentences. A sentence expresses a complete thought, and English sentences follow patterns. Once you know these patterns, you can write sentences that are clear, varied and correct, and you can spot problems like fragments and run-on sentences in your own work.

What Is a Sentence?

A **sentence** is a group of words that expresses a complete thought. It begins with a capital letter and ends with a full stop, question mark or exclamation mark. Every complete sentence has at least:

- a **subject**: who or what the sentence is about, and
- a **predicate**: what the subject does or is, which always contains a verb.

In "The students submitted their projects", the subject is *The students* and the predicate is *submitted their projects*.

Parts of a Sentence

- **Subject**: the doer or the topic. *Priya* laughed.
- **Verb**: the action or state. *Priya* *laughed*.

- **Object:** receives the action.
 - A **direct object** answers "what?" or "whom?": She wrote *a letter*.
 - An **indirect object** answers "to whom?" or "for whom?": She wrote *her grandmother* a letter.
- **Complement:** completes the meaning after a linking verb. He is *a doctor*. The soup tastes *salty*.
- **Adverbial (adjunct):** gives extra information about time, place, manner or reason. We met *at the station yesterday*.

Key idea: English follows **Subject-Verb-Object (SVO)** word order: "Riya reads books", not "Riya books reads". Many Indian languages use Subject-Object-Verb order, so this is worth practising.

The Five Basic Sentence Patterns

Pattern	Example
S + V	The baby slept.
S + V + O	The chef cooked dinner.
S + V + C	The chef is talented.
S + V + IO + DO	The chef gave us a recipe.
S + V + O + C	The chef made the kitchen spotless.

Adverbials can be added to any pattern: "The baby slept *peacefully after lunch*."

Phrases and Clauses

A **phrase** is a group of words without a subject-verb pair: *in the morning, the tall building, running quickly*. A phrase cannot stand alone as a sentence.

A **clause** is a group of words that has a subject and a verb.

- An **independent (main) clause** expresses a complete thought and can stand alone: *I finished my homework*.
- A **dependent (subordinate) clause** cannot stand alone; it depends on a main clause: *because I was tired, when the bell rang, who lives next door*.

Types of Dependent Clauses

- **Adverb clauses** act like adverbs, answering when, why, how or under what condition: "*When the bell rang*, the students left."
- **Adjective (relative) clauses** describe a noun, usually starting with *who, whom, whose, which* or *that*: "The student *who topped the class* got a scholarship."
- **Noun clauses** act as nouns: "*What she said* surprised everyone." "I know *that you tried*."

Defining and Non-Defining Relative Clauses

- A **defining** clause identifies which person or thing we mean, and has no commas: "Students *who submit late* lose marks." (Only those students.)

- A **non-defining** clause adds extra information about something already identified, and uses commas: "My brother, *who lives in Bengaluru*, is an engineer." (I have one brother; the clause just adds detail.)

Use *that* only in defining clauses. In non-defining clauses, use *which* for things and *who* for people.

Types of Sentences by Structure

Simple Sentences

One independent clause.

- "The train arrived late."
- "Riya and Meera studied and revised together." (compound subject and compound verb, but still one clause)

Compound Sentences

Two or more independent clauses joined by a coordinating conjunction (FANBOYS: for, and, nor, but, or, yet, so) or a semicolon.

- "The train arrived late, so we missed the meeting."
- "I wanted to go; however, it was raining."

Complex Sentences

One independent clause and at least one dependent clause.

- "*Because the train arrived late*, we missed the meeting."

- "We missed the meeting *because the train arrived late.*"

When the dependent clause comes first, put a comma after it.

When it comes second, you usually do not need one.

Compound-Complex Sentences

At least two independent clauses and at least one dependent clause.

- "*Although the train was late,* we reached the venue, *and* the meeting started on time."

Key idea: Good writing mixes sentence types. Too many short, simple sentences sound choppy; too many long, complex ones tire the reader. Vary them.

Types of Sentences by Purpose

- **Declarative** makes a statement: "The library opens at nine."
- **Interrogative** asks a question: "When does the library open?"
- **Imperative** gives a command or request: "Please return the book by Friday." (The subject *you* is understood.)
- **Exclamatory** expresses strong feeling: "What a beautiful campus this is!"

Forming Questions

- **Yes/no questions** move the auxiliary before the subject: "She is coming." becomes "Is she coming?" If there is no auxiliary, use *do/does/did*: "He plays chess." becomes "Does he play chess?" (not "Does he plays").
- **Wh- questions** start with a question word: "Where do you live?", "Why did she leave?"
- **Indirect questions** keep statement word order: "Can you tell me where the office *is*?", not "where is the office?"

Active and Passive Voice

In the **active voice**, the subject performs the action: "The committee *approved* the proposal."

In the **passive voice**, the subject receives the action: "The proposal *was approved* by the committee."

The passive is formed with a form of *be* plus the past participle.

Tense	Active	Passive
Simple present	They clean the room.	The room is cleaned.
Simple past	They cleaned the room.	The room was cleaned.
Present continuous	They are cleaning the room.	The room is being cleaned.
Present perfect	They have cleaned the room.	The room has been cleaned.
Future	They will clean the room.	The room will be cleaned.

Tense	Active	Passive
Modal	They must clean the room.	The room must be cleaned.

Use the passive when the doer is unknown or unimportant ("My phone was stolen"), or in scientific and formal writing where the process matters more than the person ("The samples were heated to 100 degrees"). Otherwise, prefer the active voice, which is more direct and lively.

Direct and Indirect Speech

Direct speech reports exact words in quotation marks: She said, "I am tired."

Indirect (reported) speech reports the meaning without quotation marks, usually shifting tenses back and changing pronouns and time words: She said that she *was* tired.

Direct	Indirect
"I am busy," he said.	He said that he was busy.
"I finished it," she said.	She said that she had finished it.
"I will call," he said.	He said that he would call.
" Can you help?" she asked.	She asked if I could help.
"Close the door," the teacher said.	The teacher told us to close the door.

Time and place words also change: *today* becomes *that day*, *tomorrow* becomes *the next day*, *here* becomes *there*. If the reported fact is still true, the tense need not change: "He said that the earth *moves* round the sun."

Common Sentence Errors

Fragments

A **fragment** is an incomplete sentence, missing a subject, a verb, or a main clause.

- Fragment: "Because I missed the bus."
- Fixed: "I was late because I missed the bus."

Run-On Sentences and Comma Splices

A **run-on** joins independent clauses with no punctuation; a **comma splice** joins them with only a comma.

- Wrong: "I studied all night I still failed."
- Wrong: "I studied all night, I still failed."
- Fixed: "I studied all night, but I still failed." / "I studied all night; I still failed." / "Although I studied all night, I still failed."

Misplaced and Dangling Modifiers

A **modifier** must sit next to the word it describes.

- Misplaced: "She *almost* drove her kids to school every day." (Did she almost drive?) Better: "She drove her kids to school *almost* every day."
- Dangling: "*Walking to college*, the rain started." (The rain was not walking.) Better: "*Walking to college*, I got caught in the rain."

Faulty Parallelism

Items in a list or comparison should share the same grammatical form.

- Wrong: "She likes reading, to swim and painting."
- Right: "She likes reading, swimming and painting."

Summary

- A sentence needs a subject and a predicate and expresses a complete thought.
- English uses Subject-Verb-Object order; five basic patterns build most sentences.
- Phrases lack a subject-verb pair; independent clauses stand alone; dependent clauses do not.
- Sentences can be simple, compound, complex or compound-complex, and declarative, interrogative, imperative or exclamatory.
- Prefer the active voice; use the passive when the doer is unknown or unimportant.
- Reported speech usually shifts tenses, pronouns and time words.
- Avoid fragments, run-ons, comma splices, dangling modifiers and faulty parallelism.

Practice Questions

1. Identify the subject, verb and object: "The manager sent the team an email."
2. Classify as simple, compound, complex or compound-complex: "When the results came, Asha smiled, but Rohan looked worried."
3. Convert to passive: "The students are organising a fest."
4. Convert to indirect speech: He said, "I will submit the report tomorrow."
5. Fix the error: "Having finished the exam, the hall was left quietly."

CHAPTER 3

Tenses

Tense tells us **when** something happens: in the past, the present or the future. English also uses **aspect** to show whether an action is simple, ongoing (continuous), completed (perfect) or ongoing up to a point (perfect continuous). Three times combined with four aspects give the twelve tenses. They look like a lot, but they follow a clear system.

The Big Picture

	Simple	Continuous	Perfect	Perfect continuous
Present	I work	I am working	I have worked	I have been working
Past	I worked	I was working	I had worked	I had been working
Future	I will work	I will be working	I will have worked	I will have been working

Key idea: Continuous tenses use *be + -ing*. Perfect tenses use *have + past participle*. Perfect continuous tenses use *have been + -ing*. Once you know these building blocks, you can build any tense.

Verb Forms You Need

Every verb has these forms:

- **Base form:** *go, write, play*
- **Past simple:** *went, wrote, played*
- **Past participle:** *gone, written, played*
- **Present participle (-ing form):** *going, writing, playing*

Regular verbs add *-ed* for both past forms (*play, played, played*). Irregular verbs must be learnt:

Base	Past	Past participle
begin	began	begun
break	broke	broken
bring	brought	brought
choose	chose	chosen
do	did	done
eat	ate	eaten
forget	forgot	forgotten
go	went	gone
know	knew	known
teach	taught	taught
write	wrote	written

Present Tenses

Simple Present

Form: base verb, adding *-s/-es* for *he, she, it*: *I work, she works*.

Uses:

- Habits and routines: "She *goes* to the gym every morning."
- General truths and facts: "Water *boils* at 100 degrees Celsius."
- Timetables and schedules: "The train *leaves* at 6:15."
- Permanent situations: "My parents *live* in Nagpur."

Negatives and questions use *do/does*: "He *does not play*." "Does he *play*?" Note that the main verb returns to the base form: never "does not plays".

Present Continuous

Form: *am/is/are* + *-ing*: "They *are studying*."

Uses:

- Actions happening now: "I *am writing* an email."
- Temporary situations: "She *is staying* with her cousin this month."
- Fixed future plans: "We *are meeting* the client tomorrow."
- Changing situations: "Prices *are rising*."

Stative verbs describe states, not actions, and are usually *not* used in continuous forms. These include *know, believe, understand, like, love, want, need, own, belong, seem*. Say "I *know* the answer", not "I am knowing the answer"; "I

understand", not "I am understanding".

Present Perfect

Form: *have/has* + past participle: "She *has finished*."

Uses:

- Past actions with a result now: "I *have lost* my keys." (I still cannot find them.)
- Experiences at an unspecified time: "*Have* you ever *been* to Goa?"
- Actions continuing up to now, with *for* or *since*: "We *have known* each other *for* ten years." "He *has worked* here *since* 2022."
- Recent actions with *just*, *already*, *yet*: "The results *have just been* announced."

Key idea: Do not use the present perfect with a finished time expression. Say "I *saw* him yesterday", not "I have seen him yesterday". Words like *yesterday*, *last week*, *in 2020* and *ago* need the simple past.

Present Perfect Continuous

Form: *have/has been* + *-ing*: "It *has been raining*."

Uses: actions that began in the past and are still continuing or have just stopped, emphasising duration: "I *have been waiting*

for an hour." "You look tired. *Have you been working* late?"

Past Tenses

Simple Past

Form: past form of the verb: *worked, went*. Negatives and questions use *did* + base form: "She *did not go*." "Did you see it?"

Uses:

- Completed actions at a specific past time: "We *visited* Jaipur last summer."
- A series of past actions: "He *woke up, had* breakfast and *left*."
- Past habits: "As a child, I *played* cricket every evening."
(Also: "I *used to play*".)

Past Continuous

Form: *was/were* + *-ing*: "They *were watching* TV."

Uses:

- An action in progress at a past moment: "At 8 pm I *was having* dinner."
- A background action interrupted by another: "I *was walking* home when it *started* to rain."
- Two actions in progress at the same time: "While she *was cooking*, he *was cleaning*."

Past Perfect

Form: *had* + past participle: "The train *had left*."

Use: an action completed *before* another past action or time: "When we reached the station, the train *had already left*." It makes the order of past events clear.

Past Perfect Continuous

Form: *had been* + *-ing*.

Use: duration of an activity up to a past moment: "She *had been studying* for three hours when the power went out."

Future Forms

English has several ways to talk about the future, each with a slightly different meaning.

Will + Base Form

- Predictions: "It *will rain* tomorrow."
- Instant decisions: "The phone is ringing. I **ll get** it."
- Promises and offers: "I *will help* you with the project."

Going To

- Plans already decided: "I **'m going to apply** for an internship."
- Predictions based on present evidence: "Look at those clouds. It **'s going to rain**."

Present Continuous and Simple Present for the Future

- Arrangements: "I*'m meeting* the professor at 3."
- Timetables: "The exam *starts* at 10 am."

Future Continuous

Form: *will be* + *-ing*: "This time tomorrow, I *will be flying* to Delhi." It describes an action in progress at a future time.

Future Perfect

Form: *will have* + past participle: "By next June, I *will have completed* my degree." It describes an action that will be finished before a future time.

Future Perfect Continuous

Form: *will have been* + *-ing*: "By December, she *will have been working* here for five years."

Time Expressions and Their Tenses

Expression	Usual tense
every day, usually, always, often	Simple present
now, at the moment, currently	Present continuous
ever, never, just, already, yet, so far	Present perfect
for, since (up to now)	Present perfect (continuous)
yesterday, last week, ago, in 2019	Simple past
while, when (background action)	Past continuous
by the time, before (in the past)	Past perfect
tomorrow, next week, soon	Future forms
by next year, by then	Future perfect

Common Tense Mistakes

1. "I am having two brothers." Correct: "I *have* two brothers."
(*have* for possession is stative.)
2. "I have completed my degree in 2023." Correct: "I *completed* my degree in 2023."
3. "She did not went." Correct: "She did not *go*."
4. "I am working here since 2022." Correct: "I *have been working* here since 2022."
5. "If it will rain, we will stay home." Correct: "If it *rains*, we will stay home." (No *will* in the *if* clause; see below.)

Conditional Sentences

Conditionals use tenses in fixed combinations.

Type	Meaning	Form	Example
Zero	General truth	If + present, present	If you heat ice, it melts.
First	Real future possibility	If + present, will + base	If it rains, we will cancel the trip.
Second	Unreal or unlikely present/future	If + past, would + base	If I won the lottery, I would travel the world.
Third	Unreal past (regret)	If + past perfect, would have + past participle	If I had studied, I would have passed.

In the second conditional, formal English uses *were* for all subjects: "If I *were* you, I would apologise."

Sequence of Tenses

In a complex sentence, the tense of the dependent clause often follows the main clause. If the main verb is in the past, the reported or dependent verb usually shifts to a past form: "She said that she *was* ready." "I thought you *had* left." General truths keep the present: "The teacher said that light *travels* faster than sound."

Summary

- Twelve tenses come from three times (present, past, future) and four aspects (simple, continuous, perfect, perfect continuous).
- Continuous = *be* + *-ing*; perfect = *have* + past participle.
- Use the simple present for habits and facts, and the present continuous for now and temporary actions; avoid continuous forms with stative verbs.
- Use the present perfect for experiences, results and duration up to now, but never with finished time expressions.
- The past perfect shows which past action happened first.
- Use *will*, *going to* and present forms appropriately for the future.
- Conditionals follow fixed tense patterns; never put *will* in the *if* clause of a first conditional.

Practice Questions

1. Correct the errors: "I am knowing her since childhood and we have met last week."
2. Fill in the correct tense: "When I (reach) the hall, the lecture (already, start)."
3. Choose *will* or *going to*: "I have bought the tickets. We ____ watch the match on Sunday."

4. Write one sentence for each type of conditional about your exams.
5. Explain the difference between "I have lived in Pune for five years" and "I lived in Pune for five years".

Subject-Verb Agreement and Articles

Two small areas of grammar cause a surprisingly large share of errors in student writing: making the verb agree with its subject, and choosing between *a*, *an*, *the* and no article at all. These errors rarely stop a reader from understanding you, but they make writing look careless, especially in applications, emails and exams. This chapter gives you clear rules and plenty of examples for both.

Subject-Verb Agreement

The basic rule is simple: **a singular subject takes a singular verb, and a plural subject takes a plural verb.**

- "The student *writes*." (singular)
- "The students *write*." (plural)

In the simple present, singular third-person verbs end in -s (*writes*, *goes*, *has*), while plural verbs do not. Notice the pattern: nouns add -s to become plural, but verbs add -s to become singular.

With *be*: *I am*, *he/she/it is*, *we/you/they are*; *I/he/she/it was*, *we/you/they were*.

Key idea: Find the true subject first, then match the verb to it. Most agreement errors happen because a nearby word distracts you from the real subject.

Tricky Agreement Rules

1. Words Between the Subject and the Verb

Ignore phrases that come between the subject and the verb.

- "The **box** of chocolates *is* on the table." (subject: box)
- "The **quality** of the products *has* improved." (subject: quality)
- "One of my friends *is* a doctor." (subject: one)

Phrases such as *along with*, *as well as*, *together with* and *in addition to* do not change the subject:

- "The **teacher**, along with her students, *is* going on the trip."

2. Subjects Joined by And

Two subjects joined by *and* are usually plural:

- "Riya and Meera *are* classmates."

But if the two words name one idea or one person, use singular:

- "Bread and butter *is* my usual breakfast."
- "The secretary and treasurer *has* resigned." (one person holding both roles)

3. Or, Nor, Either...Or, Neither...Nor

The verb agrees with the subject **closer** to it:

- "Either the students or the teacher *is* responsible."
- "Neither the teacher nor the students *are* responsible."

4. Each, Every, Either, Neither and Indefinite Pronouns

These words are singular:

- "**Each** of the players *has* a jersey."
- "**Every** student *needs* an ID card."
- "**Everyone** *is* welcome."
- "**Neither** of the answers *is* correct."

Also singular: *anyone, anybody, someone, somebody, no one, nobody, everything, nothing*.

Plural: *both, few, many, several*. "Both *are* ready." "Many *were* absent."

Singular or plural depending on what they refer to: *all, some, most, none, any, half*.

- "Some of the cake *is* left." (cake is uncountable)
- "Some of the cakes *are* left." (cakes is plural)

5. Collective Nouns

Collective nouns (*team, family, committee, audience, class, government*) usually take a **singular** verb when the group acts as one unit, especially in Indian and American English:

- "The team *is* winning."
- "The committee *has* made its decision."

When members act individually, a plural verb can be used, especially in British English: "The family *are* arguing among themselves." When in doubt, use singular, or rephrase: "The family members are arguing."

6. Amounts, Distances and Time

Quantities treated as one unit are singular:

- "Five hundred rupees *is* too much for this book."
- "Ten kilometres *is* a long walk."
- "Two hours *is* enough for the exam."

7. Nouns That Look Plural

Some nouns end in -s but are singular:

- Subjects of study: *mathematics, physics, economics*.
"Economics *is* my favourite subject."
- *news*: "The news *is* good."
- Diseases and games: *measles, billiards*.

Some nouns are always plural: *scissors, trousers, jeans, spectacles, goods, belongings*. "My jeans are torn." But "A pair of jeans is on sale." (subject: pair)

8. There Is / There Are

The verb agrees with the noun that *follows*:

- "There *is* a mistake in your answer."
- "There *are* three mistakes in your answer."

9. The Number vs A Number

- "**The number** of students *has* increased." (singular: the number itself)
- "**A number** of students *have* complained." (plural: several students)

10. Relative Clauses

In a relative clause, the verb agrees with the noun the relative pronoun refers to:

- "She is one of those students who *work* very hard." (*who* refers to *students*)
- "She is the only one of the students who *works* part-time." (*who* refers to *the only one*)

Articles

English has two kinds of articles:

- the **indefinite articles** *a* and *an*, used for something not specific, and
- the **definite article** *the*, used for something specific or already known.

A or An?

The choice depends on **sound**, not spelling.

- Use *a* before a consonant sound: *a book*, *a university* (you-niversity), *a one-way street* (won), *a European* (you-ropean).
- Use *an* before a vowel sound: *an apple*, *an hour* (silent h), *an honest man*, *an MBA* (em-bee-ay), *an X-ray* (ex-ray).

When to Use A/An

1. With a singular countable noun mentioned for the first time:
"I saw *a* dog in the park."
2. To mean "one": "I need *a* pen."
3. With jobs: "She is *an* engineer." (Many Indian speakers drop this article; "She is engineer" is incorrect.)
4. In expressions of rate: "twice *a* day", "fifty rupees *a* kilo".
5. In exclamations: "What *a* lovely day!"

When to Use The

1. When something has already been mentioned: "I saw a dog.
The dog was barking."

2. When the listener knows which one you mean: "Please close *the door*." (the door of this room)
3. With unique things: *the sun, the moon, the internet, the world*.
4. With superlatives and ordinals: *the best, the tallest, the first, the last*.
5. With rivers, oceans, seas, mountain ranges and deserts: *the Ganga, the Arabian Sea, the Himalayas, the Thar Desert*.
6. With plural country names and names containing *republic, kingdom* or *states*: *the Netherlands, the United States, the United Kingdom*.
7. With musical instruments: "She plays *the violin*."
8. With a singular noun representing a whole class: "*The tiger* is an endangered animal."
9. With famous buildings, newspapers and some organisations: *the Taj Mahal, the Hindu, the United Nations*.
10. With *only, same, next* (in a sequence): "*the only option*", "*the same answer*".

When to Use No Article (the Zero Article)

1. With plural and uncountable nouns used in a general sense: "*Dogs* are loyal." "*Water* is essential." "*Honesty* is important."

2. With most names of people, cities, countries and continents:
Priya, Mumbai, India, Asia.
3. With single mountains and lakes: *Mount Everest, Lake Dal.*
4. With meals, in general: "We had *lunch* at one."
5. With languages and subjects: "She speaks *French*." "I study *physics*."
6. With days, months and festivals: "on *Monday*", "in *July*",
"during *Diwali*".
7. With some places when we mean their main purpose: "go to *school*", "go to *bed*", "in *hospital*" (as a patient), "at *college*".
Compare: "My father went to *the school* to meet my teacher."
(visiting the building, not to study)

Key idea: Ask two questions. Is the noun countable and singular? Then it needs *a/an, the* or another determiner. Is it specific and known to the reader? Then use *the*.

Common Article Errors

Incorrect	Correct
He is best student in class.	He is the best student in the class.
I am going to the office by the bus.	I am going to the office by bus.
She is a honest person.	She is an honest person.
The life is beautiful.	Life is beautiful.
I want to become doctor.	I want to become a doctor.
The India is a large country.	India is a large country.
He plays guitar and the cricket.	He plays the guitar and cricket.

Note: we use no article with sports ("play cricket") but *the* with musical instruments ("play the guitar").

Putting It Together: An Editing Exercise

Original:

"The number of student in the college have increased. Each of them need a ID card, and the committee are deciding a new design. A information will be sent on the Monday."

Corrected:

"The number of students in the college **has** increased. Each of them **needs an** ID card, and the committee **is** deciding **on** a new design. **The** information will be sent on Monday."

Summary

- A singular subject takes a singular verb; a plural subject takes a plural verb. Find the true subject first.
- Ignore words between subject and verb; *along with* and *as well as* do not make a subject plural.
- With *or* and *nor*, match the closer subject; *each*, *every* and most indefinite pronouns are singular.
- Collective nouns and amounts are usually singular; *news* and subjects like *economics* are singular.
- Choose *a* or *an* by sound; use *the* for specific, known or unique things.
- Use no article for general plurals and uncountables, most proper names, meals, languages, days and sports.

Practice Questions

1. Choose the correct verb: "Neither the manager nor the employees (was / were) informed."
2. Correct the sentence: "One of the boys have lost their bag."
3. Fill in *a*, *an*, *the* or leave blank: "___ Ganga is ___ longest river in ___ India, and ___ hour-long boat ride on it is ___ unforgettable experience."
4. Explain the difference between "go to school" and "go to the school".

5. Write three sentences using *the number of* and *a number of* correctly.

Punctuation and Mechanics

Punctuation marks are the traffic signals of writing. They tell the reader when to pause, when to stop, and how ideas relate to each other. Misplaced punctuation can change meaning completely: "Let's eat, Grandma!" is an invitation, while "Let's eat Grandma!" is a horror story. This chapter covers each major punctuation mark, along with capitalisation, numbers and abbreviations.

The Full Stop (Period)

Use a full stop:

- at the end of a statement or a polite command: "The meeting is at noon." "Please submit your forms."
- in some abbreviations: *e.g.*, *i.e.*, *etc.*, *Dr.*, *Mr.* (British style often omits the full stop in *Dr* and *Mr*).

Do not add a second full stop when a sentence ends with an abbreviation: "Bring pens, pencils, erasers, etc."

The Question Mark

Use a question mark after a **direct** question: "Where is the library?"

Do not use one after an **indirect** question: "She asked where the library was."

The Exclamation Mark

Use an exclamation mark to show strong emotion or emphasis: "What a fantastic result!" Use it sparingly. In formal and academic writing, avoid it almost entirely, and never use several together ("Amazing!!!").

The Comma

The comma is the most frequently used, and misused, punctuation mark. It marks a short pause and separates parts of a sentence.

1. In Lists

Separate three or more items: "We need paper, ink, and staples." The comma before *and* in a list is called the **Oxford (serial) comma**. It is optional in many styles, but it can prevent confusion: "I thanked my parents, Sachin Tendulkar and Lata Mangeshkar" sounds as if my parents are Sachin and Lata. "I thanked my parents, Sachin Tendulkar, and Lata Mangeshkar" does not. Be consistent either way.

2. Before a Coordinating Conjunction Joining Two Independent Clauses

"I wanted to attend the seminar, but I had an exam." (Use FANBOYS: for, and, nor, but, or, yet, so.)

If the clauses are short and closely linked, the comma can be omitted: "She sang and he danced."

3. After Introductory Elements

"However, the results were disappointing." "After the lecture, we went to the canteen." "If you need help, call me."

4. Around Non-Essential Information

"My sister, who lives in Chennai, is a lawyer." "Mumbai, the financial capital of India, is very crowded." If you can remove the words without changing the basic meaning, set them off with commas.

5. With Direct Address

"Rahul, please close the window." "Thank you, sir." Missing this comma causes the "Let's eat Grandma" problem.

6. In Dates, Addresses and Numbers

"On 15 August 1947, India became independent." "She lives in Andheri, Mumbai." In the Indian numbering system, commas mark lakhs and crores: 1,00,000 (one lakh); in the international system, the same number is 100,000.

7. With Quotations

"She said, 'I will be late.'"

Common Comma Mistakes

- **Comma splice:** joining two sentences with only a comma.
"I finished the report, I emailed it." Fix: use a full stop, a semicolon, or a conjunction.

- **Comma between subject and verb:** "The students who attended the workshop, received certificates." Remove the comma.
- ****Comma before *that* in defining clauses:**** "The book, that I borrowed, is overdue." Correct: "The book that I borrowed is overdue."

Key idea: Do not put a comma wherever you would pause when speaking. Commas follow grammatical rules; learn the seven uses above and you will get most commas right.

The Semicolon

A semicolon connects two closely related independent clauses without a conjunction:

- "The exam was difficult; most students found the last section confusing."

It is also used before transition words such as *however*, *therefore*, *moreover* and *otherwise* when they join two clauses:

- "The trains were delayed; therefore, the meeting was postponed."

And it separates items in a list when the items themselves contain commas:

- "The finalists came from Pune, Maharashtra; Kochi, Kerala; and Indore, Madhya Pradesh."

The Colon

A colon introduces something that explains, lists or completes what came before it. The part before a colon should usually be a complete sentence.

- A list: "You will need three things: a pen, a calculator and your admit card."
- An explanation: "There was only one problem: nobody had the key."
- A quotation or formal statement: "The principal's message was simple: work hard and be kind."
- Times, ratios and titles: *10:30 am, a ratio of 3:1, English Grammar: A Practical Guide.*
- After the greeting in a formal letter (American style): "Dear Sir:"

Do not put a colon directly after a verb or preposition: "The ingredients are: flour, sugar and eggs" is wrong. Write "The ingredients are flour, sugar and eggs."

The Apostrophe

The apostrophe has two jobs.

1. Possession

- Singular noun: add 's: *the student's book, James's car* (or *James' car*).
- Plural noun ending in s: add only the apostrophe: *the students' books, the teachers' room*.
- Irregular plural: add 's: *the children's park, women's rights*.

2. Contractions

The apostrophe replaces missing letters: *do not = don't, it is = it's, they are = they're, I would = I'd*. Contractions are fine in informal writing but should usually be avoided in formal and academic writing.

Famous Confusions

Word	Meaning	Example
its	belonging to it	The company changed its logo.
it's	it is / it has	It's raining.
your	belonging to you	Is this your bag?
you're	you are	You're late.
their	belonging to them	Their results are out.
there	a place / there is	Put it there.
they're	they are	They're coming.
whose	belonging to whom	Whose phone is this?
who's	who is / who has	Who's calling?

Never use an apostrophe to make a plain plural: "Apple's for sale" should be "Apples for sale".

Quotation Marks

Use quotation marks for direct speech and exact quotations: She said, "The deadline is Friday." Some styles use double quotes and some single quotes; be consistent. Use the other kind for a quotation within a quotation.

Quotation marks can also mark titles of short works (articles, poems, chapters) and words used in a special sense: What does "agile" mean in this context?

In Indian and British practice, full stops and commas usually go inside the quotation marks when they belong to the quoted words.

The Hyphen and the Dash

Hyphen (-)

The hyphen joins words.

- **Compound adjectives before a noun:** *a well-known author, a part-time job, a three-year course*. But "The author is well known." (no hyphen after the noun)
- **Numbers from twenty-one to ninety-nine** written as words.
- **Some prefixes:** *ex-captain, self-confidence, re-elect*.

Dashes

The **en dash** (–) shows ranges: *pages 10–25, 2020–2024*. The **em dash** (—) marks a strong break or adds emphasis: "The answer—if there is one—lies in the data." In informal writing, a spaced hyphen is often used instead. Do not overuse dashes in formal writing.

Brackets (Parentheses)

Round brackets hold extra information that is not essential: "The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) regulates banks." They are also used for abbreviations introduced after the full term, as in the example. Square brackets show words added to a quotation by someone else.

Capitalisation

Use capital letters for:

- the first word of a sentence;
- the pronoun *I*;
- proper nouns: names of people, places, organisations, days, months, festivals, languages and nationalities: *Anil, Kolkata, Infosys, Tuesday, March, Holi, Marathi, Indian*;
- titles before names: *Professor Rao, Doctor Mehta* (but "the professor", "a doctor");

- major words in titles of books, films and articles: *The Discovery of India*;
- abbreviations and acronyms: *ISRO*, *UNESCO*, *CEO*.

Do not capitalise seasons (*summer*), general subjects (*mathematics*, but *English*, because it is a language), or directions (*north*, but *North India* as a region).

Numbers and Abbreviations

- In formal writing, spell out numbers from one to nine (or up to one hundred in some styles) and use figures for larger numbers: "three students", "250 participants".
- Always use figures for dates, times, percentages, money and measurements: *5 June*, *4:30 pm*, *12 percent*, *Rs 500*, *3 km*.
- Do not start a sentence with a figure: write "Twenty students attended", not "20 students attended".
- Write out a term in full the first time, with its abbreviation in brackets, then use the abbreviation: "Artificial intelligence (AI) is changing industries. AI tools..."
- *e.g.* means "for example"; *i.e.* means "that is". "Bring a fruit, e.g. an apple" (one example). "Bring your ID, i.e. your college card" (exactly this).

Summary

- Full stops end statements; question marks follow direct questions only; exclamation marks are rare in formal writing.
- Commas separate list items, join clauses with FANBOYS, follow introductory elements, surround non-essential information and mark direct address.
- Semicolons join related independent clauses; colons introduce lists and explanations after a complete sentence.
- Apostrophes show possession and contractions; *its* and *it's* are different words.
- Hyphens join compound adjectives before nouns; dashes show ranges and breaks.
- Capitalise proper nouns and titles; follow conventions for numbers and abbreviations.

Practice Questions

1. Punctuate: "however the principal said the results would be declared on monday"
2. Correct the comma splice in two different ways: "The lab was closed, we went to the library."
3. Choose the right word: "(Its / It's) clear that the team has lost (its / it's) confidence."
4. Add hyphens where needed: "She is a well known scientist with twenty five years of experience."

5. Explain the difference between *e.g.* and *i.e.* with your own examples.

Building Vocabulary

A rich vocabulary helps you understand what you read, express yourself precisely, and make a strong impression in interviews, emails and exams. Vocabulary is not about using long, rare words to sound clever. It is about having the *right* word available when you need it. This chapter covers how words are built, the relationships between words, commonly confused words, idioms, and practical ways to keep learning.

How Words Are Built

Many English words are made of smaller meaningful parts. Knowing these parts lets you guess the meaning of thousands of unfamiliar words.

- The **root** carries the core meaning.
- A **prefix** is added before the root and changes its meaning.
- A **suffix** is added after the root and often changes the part of speech.

For example, *unbelievable* = *un-* (not) + *believe* + *-able* (can be): "cannot be believed".

Common Prefixes

Prefix	Meaning	Examples
un-, in-, im-, il-, ir-	not	unhappy, invisible, impossible, illegal, irregular
dis-	opposite, not	disagree, dishonest
mis-	wrongly	misunderstand, misspell
re-	again	rewrite, reconsider
pre-	before	preview, prehistoric
post-	after	postpone, postgraduate
inter-	between	international, interact
sub-	under	submarine, subway
super-	above	supervise, supernatural
trans-	across	transport, translate
co-, con-, com-	together	cooperate, connect, combine
anti-	against	antibiotic, antisocial
auto-	self	automatic, autobiography

Common Suffixes

Suffix	Forms	Examples
-tion, -sion, -ment, -ness, -ity	nouns	information, decision, development, kindness, ability
-er, -or, -ist	people who do something	teacher, actor, scientist
-able, -ible	adjectives: can be done	readable, flexible
-ful, -less	adjectives: full of / without	helpful, careless
-ous, -ive, -al	adjectives	famous, creative, national
-ize / -ise, -ify	verbs	organise, simplify
-ly	adverbs	quickly, clearly

Common Roots (from Latin and Greek)

Root	Meaning	Examples
bio	life	biology, biography
graph, gram	write	autograph, telegram
tele	far	telephone, telescope
port	carry	transport, portable, export
dict	say	predict, dictionary, contradict
spect	look	inspect, spectator, perspective
scrib, script	write	describe, manuscript
duc, duct	lead	introduce, conduct
vis, vid	see	visible, video, revise
chron	time	chronological, synchronise
phon	sound	microphone, symphony
log, logy	word, study	dialogue, psychology

Key idea: When you meet an unknown word, break it into parts and combine that with the context of the sentence. You will often be able to work out the meaning without a dictionary.

Word Families

Learn words in families rather than alone. From *decide*: *decision* (noun), *decisive* (adjective), *decisively* (adverb), *indecisive* (opposite). From *economy*: *economic*, *economical*, *economist*, *economise*. Note that *economic* means "related to the economy" (economic growth) while *economical* means "saving money" (an economical car).

Synonyms and Antonyms

Synonyms have similar meanings; **antonyms** have opposite meanings.

Synonyms are rarely perfect substitutes. They differ in **strength**, **tone** and **usage**:

- *Big, large, huge, enormous, massive*: increasing strength.
- *Thin* (neutral), *slim* (positive), *skinny* (negative): different tones.
- *Start* (everyday), *commence* (formal).

Choosing the right synonym is a mark of good writing. "The committee *commenced* the meeting" suits a formal report; "Let's *start*" suits a chat.

Antonyms are often formed with prefixes (*honest, dishonest; legal, illegal*) but many are separate words (*generous, stingy; expand, contract*).

Collocations

Collocations are words that naturally go together. Native speakers say "make a decision", not "do a decision". Learning collocations makes your English sound natural.

Verb	Collocates with
make	a decision, a mistake, progress, an effort, a phone call, money
do	homework, research, business, your best, a favour
take	a break, an exam, notes, a photo, responsibility
have	a meeting, lunch, a good time, an argument
pay	attention, a visit, a compliment
catch	a cold, a bus, someone's attention

Other common collocations: *heavy rain* (not strong rain), *strong coffee* (not powerful coffee), *highly recommended*, *deeply concerned*, *bitterly disappointed*, *a fast train*, *a quick shower*.

Commonly Confused Words

Pair	Meaning and example
accept / except	<i>accept</i> = receive: "I accept your offer." <i>except</i> = excluding: "all except Ravi"
affect / effect	<i>affect</i> (verb) = influence: "Stress affects sleep." <i>effect</i> (noun) = result: "a side effect"
advice / advise	<i>advice</i> (noun): "good advice". <i>advise</i> (verb): "I advise you to rest."
lose / loose	<i>lose</i> = misplace or not win. <i>loose</i> = not tight.
principal / principle	<i>principal</i> = head of a school, or main. <i>principle</i> = a rule or belief.
stationary / stationery	<i>stationary</i> = not moving. <i>stationery</i> = pens and paper.
complement / compliment	<i>complement</i> = complete or go well with. <i>compliment</i> = praise.
weather / whether	<i>weather</i> = climate conditions. <i>whether</i> = if.
then / than	<i>then</i> = at that time or next. <i>than</i> = for comparisons.
lie / lay	<i>lie</i> = recline (no object): "Lie down." <i>lay</i> = put something down: "Lay the book on the table."
fewer / less	<i>fewer</i> for countable nouns: "fewer students". <i>less</i> for uncountable: "less water".
borrow / lend	<i>borrow</i> = take temporarily: "Can I borrow your pen?" <i>lend</i> = give temporarily: "Can you lend me your pen?"

Indian English Usages to Check in Formal Writing

Some expressions common in India can confuse international readers:

- "Do the needful": say exactly what is needed, such as "Please send the signed form."
- "Revert back" (to mean reply): use "reply" or "respond".
- "Prepone": widely understood in India, but "bring forward" or "move earlier" is safer internationally.
- "Out of station": "out of town" or "travelling".
- "Passed out of college": "graduated from college" (to *pass out* usually means to faint).
- "Kindly": fine, but do not overuse it; "please" is usually more natural.

One-Word Substitutions

Replacing a phrase with one precise word makes writing concise.

Phrase	Word
A person who does not believe in God	atheist
A government by the people	democracy
Something that cannot be read	illegible
A person who knows many languages	polyglot
Fear of heights	acrophobia

Phrase	Word
A speech made without preparation	extempore
One who looks on the bright side	optimist
That which cannot be avoided	inevitable
A place where birds are kept	aviary
Life story written by oneself	autobiography

Idioms and Phrasal Verbs

Idioms

An **idiom** is a phrase whose meaning is different from the meanings of its individual words.

Idiom	Meaning
break the ice	start a conversation in an awkward situation
a piece of cake	very easy
hit the books	study hard
once in a blue moon	very rarely
under the weather	slightly ill
cost an arm and a leg	be very expensive
the ball is in your court	it is your decision now
burn the midnight oil	work late into the night
on the same page	in agreement
get the hang of something	learn how to do something

Idioms make speech lively but are often too informal for academic writing. Use them in conversation and informal

emails.

Phrasal Verbs

A **phrasal verb** is a verb plus a particle (*up, out, off, on, down*) with a special meaning.

- *look up* (search for information), *look after* (take care of), *look forward to* (anticipate happily)
- *give up* (quit), *give in* (surrender)
- *put off* (postpone), *put up with* (tolerate)
- *carry out* (perform), *find out* (discover), *turn down* (reject)
- *come up with* (think of an idea), *run out of* (have none left)

In formal writing, a single-word verb is often better: *postpone* instead of *put off*, *investigate* instead of *look into*.

How to Build Your Vocabulary

1. **Read widely and regularly.** Newspapers, novels, magazines and good blogs expose you to words in context. Even 20 minutes a day adds up.
2. **Learn words in context, not lists.** Write down the whole sentence in which you found a new word.
3. **Keep a vocabulary notebook or app.** Record the word, its meaning, part of speech, an example sentence and related words.

4. **Use spaced repetition.** Review new words after one day, three days, a week and a month. Flashcard apps do this automatically, and so does this book's game.
5. **Use new words actively.** Try each word in speech or writing at least three times within a week.
6. **Learn word families and collocations,** not just single meanings.
7. **Play with words:** crosswords, word games and quizzes make practice enjoyable.

Key idea: A word is truly learnt when you can *use* it correctly, not merely recognise it. Active use and spaced review turn passive vocabulary into active vocabulary.

Summary

- Roots, prefixes and suffixes let you decode unfamiliar words.
- Learn words in families, and notice differences in strength and tone between synonyms.
- Collocations (*make a decision, heavy rain*) make English sound natural.
- Master commonly confused pairs such as *affect/effect* and *principal/principle*, and check Indian English usages in formal writing.

- One-word substitutions make writing concise; idioms and phrasal verbs suit informal contexts.
- Build vocabulary through wide reading, context, spaced repetition and active use.

Practice Questions

1. Break these words into prefix, root and suffix and give their meanings: *transportation*, *unpredictable*, *inspector*.
2. Choose the correct word: "The new policy will (affect / effect) all students, and its (affect / effect) will be seen next year."
3. Fill in *make*, *do* or *take*: "____ a decision", "____ your homework", "____ notes", "____ a mistake".
4. Give one word for: "a person who loves books", "a word opposite in meaning".
5. Rewrite formally: "Please do the needful and revert back by tomorrow."

Reading Comprehension

Reading is the foundation of every other language skill. You read textbooks, research papers, emails, instructions, news and, in placement tests and competitive exams, timed comprehension passages. Good readers do not simply read faster; they read **actively**, with a purpose, adjusting their approach to the text. This chapter explains reading strategies, how to handle different kinds of questions, and how to improve speed without losing understanding.

Why Comprehension Is More Than Reading Words

You can read every word of a paragraph and still not understand it. Comprehension means grasping:

- the **main idea**: what the passage is mainly about;
- the **supporting details**: facts, examples and reasons;
- the **structure**: how ideas connect;
- the **author's purpose and tone**: why and how it was written; and
- **implied meanings**: what the author suggests but does not say directly.

Key idea: Active readers constantly ask questions: What is this about? Why is the author telling me this? How does this connect to what came before?

Reading Techniques

Skimming

Skimming means reading quickly to get the general idea. Read the title, headings, the first and last paragraphs, and the first sentence of each paragraph (which is often the **topic sentence**). Use skimming to preview a chapter, decide whether an article is relevant, or get an overview of a comprehension passage before reading it closely.

Scanning

Scanning means searching quickly for specific information: a date, a name, a number or a keyword. Your eyes move rapidly over the text until they find what you need. Use scanning to answer factual questions or to find a timing in a train timetable.

Intensive Reading

Intensive reading means reading carefully and slowly for full understanding: every sentence, every argument. Use it for textbooks, contracts, instructions and the key parts of an exam passage.

Extensive Reading

Extensive reading means reading large amounts for pleasure or general knowledge: novels, magazines, long articles. It builds vocabulary, fluency and general knowledge over time.

The SQ3R Method

SQ3R is a well-known study-reading method:

1. **Survey:** skim the headings, summaries and diagrams to get an overview.
2. **Question:** turn headings into questions. "Causes of Inflation" becomes "What causes inflation?"
3. **Read:** read actively to answer your questions.
4. **Recite:** close the book and say or write the main points in your own words.
5. **Review:** go over your notes later to strengthen memory.

This method turns passive reading into active learning.

Understanding Paragraph Structure

Most well-written paragraphs have:

- a **topic sentence** stating the main idea, usually at the start;
- **supporting sentences** giving explanations, evidence and examples; and

- sometimes a **concluding sentence** that sums up or links to the next paragraph.

Signal words (transitions) reveal how ideas relate:

Relationship	Signal words
Addition	also, moreover, furthermore, in addition
Contrast	however, but, although, on the other hand, whereas
Cause and effect	because, therefore, as a result, consequently
Example	for example, for instance, such as
Sequence	first, then, next, finally
Conclusion	in conclusion, thus, overall, to sum up

Words like *however* and *but* are especially important: what comes after them is often the author's real point.

Types of Comprehension Questions

1. Main Idea Questions

"What is the passage mainly about?" or "Which title best suits the passage?"

Strategy: look for the idea that covers the *whole* passage. Wrong options are often too narrow (covering one paragraph) or too broad (going beyond the passage).

2. Detail (Factual) Questions

"According to the passage, when was the bridge built?"

Strategy: scan for keywords from the question and read the surrounding sentences carefully. The answer is stated directly, often in slightly different words (a **paraphrase**).

3. Inference Questions

"What can be inferred from the passage?" or "The author implies that..."

Strategy: the answer is not stated directly but must follow logically from the text. Avoid options that go too far or rely on outside knowledge. A correct inference is *supported by* the passage, not merely *possible*.

4. Vocabulary in Context

"The word *mitigate* in paragraph 2 most nearly means..."

Strategy: reread the sentence and substitute each option. The right answer fits the context, even if another option is a more common meaning of the word.

5. Author's Purpose and Tone

"Why does the author mention the survey?" or "The tone of the passage is..."

Common purposes: to inform, persuade, explain, entertain, criticise or compare. Tone words include *objective*, *critical*, *optimistic*, *sarcastic*, *nostalgic*, *cautious*, *enthusiastic* and *neutral*.

6. Structure and Function

"How is the passage organised?" (problem and solution, cause and effect, chronological, comparison) or "What is the function of the third paragraph?"

7. True/False/Not Given

Some tests ask whether a statement is true, false or **not given**.

"Not given" means the passage neither confirms nor contradicts it. Do not use your own knowledge.

Key idea: In comprehension tests, the passage is the only source of truth. An option that is true in real life but not supported by the passage is wrong.

A Worked Example

Urban gardens are spreading across Indian cities. On rooftops in Bengaluru and balconies in Mumbai, residents are growing vegetables, herbs and flowers. Supporters argue that such gardens reduce household expenses and improve mental well-being. However, critics point out that without proper waterproofing, rooftop gardens can damage buildings. Experts therefore recommend professional advice before starting large rooftop projects.

- **Main idea:** urban gardening is growing in Indian cities and has benefits but needs care.

- **Detail:** Where are balcony gardens mentioned? Mumbai.
- **Inference:** Some rooftop gardens have probably caused building damage. (Supported by the critics' concern.)
- **Vocabulary:** "proper" most nearly means "suitable" or "correct".
- **Purpose:** to inform readers about a trend and its pros and cons.
- **Tone:** balanced and objective.
- **Signal word:** "However" introduces the opposing view; "therefore" introduces the conclusion.

Strategies for Timed Tests

1. **Read the questions first** (or at least skim them) so you know what to look for.
2. **Skim the passage** for the main idea and structure, marking key words.
3. **Answer detail questions** by scanning back to the relevant lines.
4. **Eliminate wrong options:** extreme words (*always, never, all, completely*) are often wrong; options that are true but irrelevant are wrong.

5. **Manage time:** do not get stuck on one hard question. Mark it and return later.
6. **For inference questions,** choose the option that needs the smallest logical step from the text.

Reading Critically

At college level, understanding is not enough; you must also **evaluate**.

- **Fact vs opinion:** "The dam was completed in 2010" is a fact that can be checked. "The dam was a waste of money" is an opinion.
- **Evidence:** Does the author support claims with data, examples or expert sources?
- **Bias:** Does the author present only one side? Who wrote it, and why?
- **Logic:** Do the conclusions follow from the evidence?
- **Currency:** Is the information up to date?

These questions are essential when reading news and social media, where misinformation spreads quickly.

Improving Reading Speed

- **Read in chunks:** train your eyes to take in groups of words rather than one word at a time.

- **Reduce subvocalisation:** try not to "say" every word silently in your head, which limits you to speaking speed.
- **Avoid regression:** resist rereading every line; reread only when truly necessary.
- **Preview first:** knowing the structure lets you read faster.
- **Practise regularly** with timed reading, gradually increasing difficulty.

Speed should never cost comprehension. The goal is *efficient* reading: fast where the text is easy, slow where it matters.

Making Notes While Reading

- Underline or highlight sparingly: only key ideas, not whole paragraphs.
- Write short notes in the margin: "definition", "example", "author disagrees".
- Summarise each section in one or two sentences in your own words.
- Use **mind maps** to show how ideas connect, or the **Cornell method**: divide your page into notes, key questions, and a summary at the bottom.

Summary

- Comprehension means understanding main ideas, details, structure, purpose, tone and implications.
- Skim for the general idea, scan for specific facts, read intensively for depth and extensively for fluency.
- SQ3R (survey, question, read, recite, review) makes study reading active.
- Topic sentences and signal words reveal structure.
- Learn the main question types: main idea, detail, inference, vocabulary, purpose and tone, structure, and true/false/not given.
- In tests, rely only on the passage and eliminate extreme or irrelevant options.
- Read critically: separate fact from opinion, and check evidence and bias.

Practice Questions

1. Explain the difference between skimming and scanning, with one situation for each.
2. Turn these headings into SQ3R questions: "Effects of Deforestation", "The Water Cycle".
3. In the urban gardens passage, which sentence shows the author's conclusion? Which signal word introduces it?

4. Classify as fact or opinion: "Mumbai receives heavy rainfall during the monsoon." "Mumbai is the most exciting city in India."
5. Why are answer options containing *always* or *never* often wrong in comprehension tests?

Writing Paragraphs and Essays

Clear writing is clear thinking made visible. Whether you are answering an exam question, writing a lab report, drafting a statement of purpose or posting on a professional network, the same principles apply: know your point, organise your ideas, support them with evidence, and express them simply. This chapter builds from the paragraph to the full essay, and covers the writing process from planning to proofreading.

The Paragraph

A **paragraph** is a group of sentences that develops **one main idea**. A good paragraph has three qualities:

- **Unity:** every sentence relates to the main idea.
- **Coherence:** sentences follow a logical order and connect smoothly.
- **Adequate development:** the idea is explained and supported enough to convince the reader.

The Structure of a Paragraph

1. **Topic sentence:** states the main idea, usually at the beginning.

2. **Supporting sentences:** explain, give reasons, provide examples, facts or evidence.
3. **Concluding sentence:** sums up or links to the next paragraph (optional in short pieces).

The PEEL Method

A reliable pattern for body paragraphs in essays:

- **Point:** state your claim.
- **Evidence:** give facts, data, examples or quotations.
- **Explain:** show how the evidence supports your point.
- **Link:** connect back to the main argument or to the next paragraph.

Example:

(P) Public libraries remain important in the digital age. **(E)** A 2024 survey found that more than half of library visitors in large Indian cities used them for free internet access and quiet study space. **(E)** This shows that libraries provide resources that many students cannot afford at home. **(L)** Therefore, cutting library funding would widen the gap between students of different incomes.

Key idea: One paragraph, one idea. If you find yourself starting a new idea, start a new paragraph.

Achieving Coherence

- Use **transition words**: *first, moreover, however, for example, as a result, finally*.
- **Repeat key terms** or use pronouns and synonyms to link sentences.
- Follow a clear **order**: chronological (time), spatial (place), order of importance, general to specific, or problem to solution.

Types of Paragraphs and Essays

Type	Purpose	Example topic
Descriptive	Paint a picture with sensory detail	A monsoon evening in Kerala
Narrative	Tell a story or sequence of events	My first day at college
Expository	Explain or inform objectively	How UPI payments work
Argumentative / persuasive	Take a position and convince	Should attendance be compulsory?
Compare and contrast	Show similarities and differences	Online vs classroom learning
Cause and effect	Explain why something happens and its results	Causes and effects of air pollution

The Structure of an Essay

Most academic essays follow a three-part structure.

1. Introduction

The introduction should:

- **hook** the reader: a striking fact, a question, a short anecdote or a quotation;
- give **context**: a little background on the topic; and
- end with a **thesis statement**: one or two sentences stating your main argument or the essay's purpose.

A strong thesis is **specific** and **arguable**.

- Weak: "Social media has advantages and disadvantages."
(too vague)
- Strong: "Although social media helps students collaborate, its constant notifications reduce concentration, so colleges should teach digital self-discipline."

2. Body Paragraphs

Each body paragraph develops **one** supporting point for the thesis, typically using PEEL. A short essay usually has three body paragraphs. Order them logically, for example building up to your strongest point.

In an argumentative essay, include a **counter-argument** and **rebuttal**: acknowledge the opposing view fairly, then explain why your position is still stronger. This makes your argument more convincing, not weaker.

3. Conclusion

The conclusion should:

- **restate the thesis** in fresh words (do not copy it);
- **summarise** the main points briefly; and
- end with a **final thought**: a recommendation, a call to action, a wider implication or a question for the future.

Do not introduce completely new arguments in the conclusion.

The Writing Process

Good writing is rarely produced in one go. Follow these stages.

1. Understand the Task

Read the question carefully. Identify **instruction words**:

- *Describe*: give the features.
- *Explain*: give reasons and how something works.
- *Discuss*: examine different sides.
- *Evaluate / assess*: judge strengths and weaknesses and reach a conclusion.
- *Compare*: show similarities (and often differences).
- *Justify*: give reasons for a position.

2. Brainstorm

Generate ideas freely: list points, draw a mind map, or free-write for five minutes without stopping.

3. Plan and Outline

Choose your thesis and three or four main points, and arrange them logically. A quick outline saves time and prevents rambling.

Thesis: Colleges should adopt a four-day class week.

1. Improves student well-being (evidence: stress survey)
2. Frees time for internships and projects
3. Counter-argument: less teaching time -> rebuttal:
longer, focused sessions

Conclusion: pilot the idea for one semester

4. Draft

Write the first version without worrying too much about perfection. Focus on getting your ideas down in the planned order.

5. Revise

Revising means improving the **content and organisation**:

- Is the thesis clear? Does every paragraph support it?
- Is the evidence convincing? Is anything missing or irrelevant?
- Is the order logical? Are transitions smooth?

6. Edit and Proofread

Editing focuses on **sentences and words**; proofreading on **surface errors**.

- Cut unnecessary words. "Due to the fact that" becomes "because"; "in order to" becomes "to"; "at this point in time" becomes "now".
- Replace vague words (*things, stuff, very good*) with precise ones.
- Check grammar, spelling, punctuation, agreement and tense.
- Read aloud; awkward sentences become obvious.

Key idea: Separate writing from editing. Trying to write perfect sentences on the first draft slows you down and blocks your ideas.

Style: Writing Clearly

1. **Prefer short, simple words:** *use* rather than *utilise*, *help* rather than *facilitate*.
2. **Keep sentences focused:** aim for an average of 15 to 20 words, with variety.
3. **Use the active voice** in most cases: "The team designed the app", not "The app was designed by the team".

4. **Be specific:** "Sales rose by 18 percent in March" beats "Sales increased a lot recently".
5. **Avoid clichés and filler:** "in today's modern world", "since time immemorial", "last but not the least".
6. **Keep a consistent tone:** formal for academic work (no slang, contractions or text-speak).

Academic Integrity

Using other people's words or ideas without credit is **plagiarism**, and colleges treat it seriously.

- **Quote** exact words in quotation marks and cite the source.
- **Paraphrase** by restating ideas completely in your own words and sentence structure, and still cite the source.
- **Summarise** the main points briefly in your own words, with a citation.
- Use a consistent citation style (APA, MLA, IEEE) as your department requires.

AI writing tools can help you brainstorm or check grammar, but submitting AI-generated text as your own work is usually treated as academic misconduct. Follow your college's rules.

Writing Under Exam Conditions

1. Spend about **10 percent** of the time planning, **80 percent** writing and **10 percent** checking.
2. Answer the exact question, using its keywords in your thesis.
3. Use clear paragraphs; examiners reward structure.
4. Keep an eye on the word limit; writing more is not always better.
5. Leave time to proofread for obvious errors.

A Sample Short Essay Outline

Topic: "Should mobile phones be allowed in classrooms?"

- **Introduction:** hook with a statistic on smartphone use among students; thesis: phones should be allowed only for supervised learning activities.
- **Body 1:** educational benefits: instant research, learning apps, accessibility tools.
- **Body 2:** distractions and cheating risks, with evidence on attention.
- **Body 3 (counter-argument and rebuttal):** a full ban is simpler; but clear rules and teacher control preserve the benefits while limiting harm.
- **Conclusion:** restate the balanced position; recommend a clear classroom phone policy.

Summary

- A paragraph develops one idea with a topic sentence, support and, optionally, a conclusion; aim for unity, coherence and development.
- PEEL (point, evidence, explain, link) structures strong body paragraphs.
- Essays have an introduction with a hook and a specific, arguable thesis, body paragraphs that support it, and a conclusion that restates and reflects.
- Follow the writing process: understand, brainstorm, outline, draft, revise, edit and proofread.
- Write clearly: simple words, active voice, specific details, no filler.
- Credit sources to avoid plagiarism; plan your time carefully in exams.

Practice Questions

1. Write a topic sentence and three supporting sentences on "The benefits of learning a second language."
2. Improve this thesis: "Pollution is a big problem."
3. Write a PEEL paragraph arguing for or against compulsory internships.

4. Make these phrases concise: "due to the fact that", "in the event that", "a large number of".
5. Outline a five-paragraph essay on "Online learning vs classroom learning".

Formal Letters, Emails and Workplace Writing

At college and at work, much of your communication is written: emails to professors, internship applications, complaint letters, meeting minutes and reports. These documents are judged quickly, often by busy readers, and they shape how people see you. A clear, polite, well-organised email can open doors; a careless one can close them. This chapter covers the formats and etiquette of formal written communication.

Principles of Professional Writing

Remember the **7 Cs** of business communication. Good messages are:

1. **Clear:** the purpose is obvious and the language simple.
2. **Concise:** no unnecessary words or repetition.
3. **Concrete:** specific facts, figures and dates rather than vague statements.
4. **Correct:** accurate information, grammar, spelling and names.
5. **Coherent:** ideas flow logically.

6. **Complete:** the reader has everything needed to understand and act.
7. **Courteous:** polite and respectful, even when complaining or refusing.

Key idea: Before writing, ask: Who is my reader? What do I want them to know or do? Then put the most important point first.

Formal Letters

Formal letters are still used for official applications, complaints, legal matters and correspondence with government offices.

Layout (Block Format)

In the modern **block format**, everything is aligned to the left.

1. **Sender's address** (and optionally phone and email)
2. **Date:** *26 September 2026*
3. **Receiver's designation and address:** *The Principal,
ABC College of Engineering, Pune 411001*
4. **Subject line:** a short statement of purpose, often in bold:
Subject: Request for a bonafide certificate
5. **Salutation:** *Dear Sir/Madam*, or *Dear Dr Sharma*, (use the name if you know it)

6. **Body:**

- *Opening paragraph:* state who you are and why you are writing.
- *Middle paragraph(s):* give details, reasons and supporting information.
- *Closing paragraph:* state what action you request and thank the reader.

7. **Complimentary close:** *Yours faithfully*, (when the salutation is "Dear Sir/Madam") or *Yours sincerely*, (when you used the person's name)

8. **Signature and name**, with designation or roll number if relevant

9. **Enclosures:** *Encl: Copy of fee receipt*

Sample Letter of Request

Riya Sharma
B-12, Green Park Society
Pune 411038

26 September 2026

The Principal
ABC College of Engineering
Pune 411001

Subject: Request for a bonafide certificate

Dear Sir/Madam,

I am a third-year student of Computer Engineering (Roll No. 21CE045).

I am writing to request a bonafide certificate, which I need to apply for an educational loan from State Bank of India.

I have attached a copy of my college ID card and the bank's letter.

I would be grateful if the certificate could be issued by 5 October 2026, as the loan application closes on 8 October.

Thank you for your time and assistance.

Yours faithfully,
Riya Sharma

Encl: (1) Copy of ID card (2) Bank's letter

Types of Formal Letters

- **Letter of request / application:** leave, certificates, permissions.
- **Complaint letter:** state the problem factually, give details (dates, order numbers), describe the impact, and request a specific solution. Stay polite and firm.
- **Letter to the editor:** express an opinion on a public issue, with reasons and suggestions.
- **Cover letter:** accompanies a job or internship application (see below).
- **Letter of enquiry:** requests information, such as about a course or product.

Emails

Email is the main written channel in most workplaces and colleges. Its informality in speed does not mean informality in style.

Parts of a Professional Email

1. **Subject line:** specific and short. "Request to reschedule DBMS viva (Roll No. 21CE045)" is far better than "Hi" or "Urgent".
2. **Salutation:**
 - Formal: *Dear Professor Kulkarni, / Dear Ms Mehta,*
 - Neutral: *Hello Mr Singh,*

- Avoid *Hey*, *Hi Sir* and *Respected Sir* in international or modern professional contexts; *Dear Sir/Madam* is fine when you do not know the name.
- 3. **Opening line:** state your purpose immediately. "I am writing to ask whether..." Introduce yourself if the reader does not know you.
- 4. **Body:** short paragraphs, one idea each. Use bullet points for several items or questions.
- 5. **Call to action:** state clearly what you need and by when.
- 6. **Closing:** *Best regards*, / *Kind regards*, / *Thank you*, followed by your full name and relevant details (course, roll number, phone).

Sample Email to a Professor

Subject: Request for extension - ML assignment 2 (Roll No. 21CE045)

Dear Professor Kulkarni,

I am writing to request a two-day extension for Machine Learning Assignment 2, which is due on Friday, 3 October.

I was admitted to hospital from 28 to 30 September with a viral fever, and I have attached the discharge summary. I have completed the data preprocessing and model training sections, and I need a little more time to finish the evaluation and report.

Would it be possible to submit the assignment by Sunday, 5 October?
I would be grateful for your consideration.

Kind regards,
Riya Sharma
TE Computer Engineering, Division A

Email Etiquette

- **Reply promptly**, ideally within one working day, even if only to acknowledge.
- **Keep it short**: if an email needs scrolling, consider whether a call or meeting would be better.

- ****Use *Reply all* carefully, **** only when everyone needs your response.
- **Use CC and BCC correctly:** *To* is for people who must act; *CC* for people who should be informed; *BCC* hides recipients from each other (useful for large mailing lists).
- **Attach files properly** and mention them in the text. Check that the attachment is really there before sending.
- **Avoid** all capitals (it reads as shouting), text-speak (*pls*, *u*, *thx*), excessive exclamation marks and emojis in formal emails.
- **Proofread** names, dates, figures and attachments before clicking send.
- **Never write in anger.** Draft, wait, and reread before sending a sensitive message.
- Remember that emails are **permanent** and can be forwarded. Do not write anything you would not want seen by others.

Key idea: A good subject line and a clear first sentence let a busy reader understand your email in five seconds.

Cover Letters

A **cover letter** introduces you when applying for a job or internship. It should be tailored to each position and fit on one page.

1. **Opening:** the position you are applying for, where you saw it, and a one-line hook about why you are a strong fit.
2. **Middle (one or two paragraphs):** your most relevant skills and achievements, with evidence. "I built a Flask web app used by 300 students for timetable management" is stronger than "I have good programming skills."
3. **Why this organisation:** show that you have researched them.
4. **Closing:** express enthusiasm, mention your attached resume, and request an interview.

Match your language to the job description, and never send the same generic letter to every company.

Resumes in Brief

A resume (or CV) summarises your qualifications. For students:

- **Contact details:** name, phone, professional email, LinkedIn or GitHub.
- **Education:** degree, college, year, CGPA.

- **Skills:** technical and relevant soft skills.
- **Projects and internships:** what you did, tools used, and results, starting each point with an **action verb** (*developed, designed, analysed, led, improved*).
- **Achievements and activities:** competitions, certifications, positions of responsibility.

Keep it to one page, use a clean layout, and make sure every claim can be discussed in an interview.

Other Workplace Documents

Memos

A **memo** is a short internal document for announcements or instructions within an organisation. It has headings (*To, From, Date, Subject*) and a brief, direct body. Today, many memos are sent as emails.

Notices

A **notice** announces an event or information to a group, often on a notice board or website. It includes the organisation's name, the word NOTICE, a date, a clear heading, the essential details (what, when, where, who) and the issuer's name and designation. It is usually placed in a box and kept brief.

Minutes of Meetings

Minutes record what happened in a meeting: date, time, place, attendees, apologies, each agenda item, key discussions, **decisions made** and **action items** (who will do what by when). They are written in the past tense and in neutral language.

Reports

A formal **report** presents information and analysis for decision-making. A typical structure is: title page, executive summary, introduction (purpose and scope), methodology, findings, conclusions, recommendations and appendices. Use headings, numbered sections and tables so readers can find information quickly.

Summary

- Professional messages follow the 7 Cs: clear, concise, concrete, correct, coherent, complete and courteous.
- Formal letters use block format with addresses, date, subject, salutation, a three-part body, a matching close and signature.
- Professional emails need a specific subject line, an appropriate salutation, a clear purpose, short paragraphs, a call to action and a proper sign-off.
- Follow email etiquette: reply promptly, use CC and BCC correctly, check attachments, avoid text-speak and never write in anger.

- Cover letters and resumes should be tailored, evidence-based and concise.
- Memos, notices, minutes and reports each have standard formats.

Practice Questions

1. Write a formal letter to your college librarian requesting permission to borrow reference books during the vacation.
2. Rewrite this email subject line to be more effective:
"Regarding the thing".
3. Write an email to a company's HR department following up on an internship application you sent two weeks ago.
4. What is the difference between CC and BCC? When would you use BCC?
5. Draft the minutes of a 30-minute student committee meeting about organising a technical fest.

Speaking and Presentation Skills

Good ideas need to be heard. In college you will present projects, take part in group discussions and face viva examinations. At work you will attend interviews, pitch ideas and lead meetings. Spoken communication can feel more stressful than writing, because it happens in real time, but it is a skill like any other: it improves with preparation and practice. This final chapter covers the basics of clear speaking, presentations, group discussions and interviews.

Elements of Effective Speaking

Clarity and Pronunciation

You do not need a "foreign" accent to speak English well. Indian English is a respected variety of English. What matters is being **clearly understood**.

- **Speak at a moderate pace.** Nervous speakers rush. Aim for about 130 to 150 words per minute.
- **Articulate** word endings and consonants clearly, especially in technical terms.

- **Stress the right syllable:** *de-VE-lop*, *PHO-to-graph* but *pho-TO-gra-phy*, *e-CO-no-my*. Wrong stress causes more misunderstanding than accent does.
- **Pause** at the end of ideas. Pauses give listeners time to think and make you sound confident.

Voice

- **Volume:** loud enough for the person at the back of the room to hear.
- **Pitch and intonation:** vary your tone; a flat, monotonous voice loses attention. Rising intonation signals a question; falling intonation signals a statement or conclusion.
- **Emphasis:** stress key words to highlight important points: "This method is *three times* faster."

Fillers

Fillers like *um*, *uh*, *like*, *basically*, *actually* and *you know* distract listeners when overused. Replace them with a brief, silent pause. Recording yourself is the fastest way to notice your habits.

Non-Verbal Communication

Research on communication consistently finds that listeners judge speakers heavily on non-verbal signals.

- **Eye contact:** look at different people in the audience for a few seconds each. In interviews, maintain natural eye contact with the interviewer.
- **Posture:** stand or sit straight, with shoulders relaxed. Avoid leaning on the table or crossing your arms.
- **Gestures:** use open, natural hand gestures to emphasise points. Avoid fidgeting with pens, hair or your phone.
- **Facial expression:** a genuine smile at the start builds rapport.
- **Movement:** move with purpose; do not pace back and forth.

Key idea: Confidence is largely *shown* through body language. Even when nervous inside, a steady posture, eye contact and a calm pace make you appear confident, and often make you feel more confident too.

Listening Skills

Communication is two-way. **Active listening** means:

- giving full attention without planning your reply;
- showing interest through nods and brief responses ("I see", "That's a good point");
- asking clarifying questions ("Do you mean...?");

- paraphrasing to confirm understanding ("So you are suggesting that..."); and
- not interrupting.

Good listeners make better speakers, especially in discussions and interviews.

Presentations

Planning

1. **Know your audience:** What do they already know? What do they need? A presentation on your ML project would be very different for classmates, professors and a non-technical audience.
2. **Define your purpose:** to inform, persuade, demonstrate or update.
3. **Choose your key message:** if the audience remembers only one sentence, what should it be?
4. **Research and select content:** include only what supports your message. Three main points are easier to follow than ten.

Structure

Use a simple, proven structure: *tell them what you will tell them, tell them, then tell them what you told them.*

- **Opening (about 10 percent):** grab attention with a question, a surprising fact, a short story or a demonstration. Introduce yourself and the topic, and preview the main points.
- **Body (about 80 percent):** present your main points in a logical order, with evidence and examples for each. Use **signposting** language so listeners know where you are:
 - "First, I'll explain the problem."
 - "Moving on to the results..."
 - "This brings me to my final point."
- **Closing (about 10 percent):** summarise the main points, restate the key message, and end strongly: a call to action, a memorable line or a look ahead. Then invite questions.

Designing Slides

Slides should **support** you, not replace you.

- **One idea per slide,** with a clear headline stating the point, such as "Accuracy improved by 12 percent", rather than just "Results".
- **Minimal text:** use the "6 x 6" guideline as a maximum (no more than six bullet points of about six words each), or better, use visuals.
- **Readable fonts:** at least 24 point for body text, with high contrast between text and background.

- **Visuals:** charts, diagrams and images explain faster than text. Label axes and keep charts simple.
- **Consistency:** the same fonts, colours and layout throughout.
- **Avoid** reading slides aloud word for word, flashy animations and cluttered templates.

Delivering the Presentation

- **Rehearse aloud** several times, ideally in front of friends, and time yourself.
- **Know your opening and closing** almost by heart; they are when nerves are strongest and attention highest.
- Use **notes or cue cards** with keywords, not full sentences.
- **Face the audience**, not the screen.
- **Check the technology** beforehand: projector, clicker, internet and backup copies of your file.
- For a **live demo**, prepare a recorded backup in case something fails.

Handling Questions

- **Listen to the whole question** without interrupting.
- **Repeat or paraphrase** it if the room is large, so everyone hears it and you gain a moment to think.

- **Answer briefly and directly.**
- If you do not know, say so honestly: "That's a good question. I haven't tested that yet, but I'll look into it." Never bluff.
- **Stay calm and polite** even with challenging questions.

Managing Nervousness

Nearly everyone feels nervous before speaking in public. Useful techniques:

- **Prepare thoroughly:** preparation is the best cure for anxiety.
- **Breathe slowly and deeply** before starting: breathe in for four counts and out for six.
- **Reframe** nervousness as excitement; the physical feelings are almost the same.
- **Focus on the audience and the message**, not on yourself.
- **Start strong:** a well-rehearsed opening builds momentum.
- **Accept small mistakes;** the audience rarely notices them as much as you do.

Group Discussions

Many companies and colleges use **group discussions (GDs)** to assess communication, teamwork and leadership. A group of six to twelve people discusses a topic for 10 to 20 minutes while evaluators observe.

What Evaluators Look For

- **Content:** relevant, logical points with examples and facts.
- **Communication:** clarity, fluency and confidence.
- **Listening and teamwork:** building on others' points and respecting different views.
- **Leadership:** initiating, guiding the discussion back on track, summarising.

Tips for Group Discussions

1. **Initiate if you can** with a strong, relevant opening (define the topic, give context or a key fact), but only if you are prepared.
2. **Make quality contributions**, not the most contributions. Three thoughtful points beat ten repetitive ones.
3. **Use polite language to agree and disagree:**
 - "I agree with Priya, and I'd like to add that..."
 - "That's an interesting point, but I see it differently because..."

- "Could we also consider the impact on small businesses?"
- 4. **Bring in quieter members:** "Rohan, what do you think?"
This shows leadership.
- 5. **Never shout, interrupt aggressively or attack people personally.**
- 6. **Summarise at the end** if the moderator asks or the group has not concluded.

Interviews

Before the Interview

- **Research the organisation:** its products, values and recent news.
- **Study the job description** and match your skills and projects to it.
- **Prepare examples** of your achievements using the **STAR method**:
 - **Situation:** the context.
 - **Task:** your responsibility.
 - **Action:** what you did.
 - **Result:** the outcome, with numbers if possible.
- **Practise common questions** aloud (see below).
- **Prepare questions** to ask the interviewer.

Common Interview Questions

Question	What they want to know
Tell me about yourself.	A brief professional summary: education, key skills, a highlight, and why you are here (about one minute).
Why do you want to work here?	That you have researched them and your goals match.
What are your strengths?	Relevant strengths backed by examples.
What is your biggest weakness?	Self-awareness and effort to improve (choose a real, non-critical weakness and explain what you are doing about it).
Describe a challenge you faced.	Problem-solving; answer with STAR.
Where do you see yourself in five years?	Ambition that fits the role.
Do you have any questions for us?	Interest and preparation; always ask one or two thoughtful questions.

During the Interview

- **Arrive early** (or log in early for online interviews, having tested your camera, microphone and internet connection).
- **Dress appropriately** for the organisation.
- **Greet politely**, with a smile and a firm handshake where appropriate.
- **Listen carefully** and take a moment to think before answering.

- **Be honest**; it is fine to say you do not know something and explain how you would find out.
- **Show enthusiasm** for the role.
- **Thank the interviewers** at the end, and consider sending a short thank-you email afterwards.

Online Communication

Video calls are now routine for classes, interviews and meetings.

- Test your **audio and video** in advance and use headphones if possible.
- Choose a **quiet, well-lit place** with a neutral background; light should face you, not come from behind.
- Look at the **camera** when speaking to create eye contact.
- **Mute** when not speaking in group calls, and use the chat or "raise hand" features politely.
- **Dress** as you would in person.

Summary

- Clear speaking depends on pace, articulation, correct word stress, pauses and a varied voice, not on accent.
- Non-verbal signals such as eye contact, posture and gestures strongly affect how you are perceived.

- Active listening improves every conversation.
- Plan presentations around the audience and one key message; structure them with an opening, a signposted body and a strong close.
- Design simple, visual slides; rehearse aloud; handle questions honestly.
- In group discussions, contribute quality points, respect others and help the group reach conclusions.
- Prepare for interviews with research and STAR stories, and communicate professionally online.

Practice Questions

1. Record yourself giving a two-minute talk on your favourite subject. List your fillers and pace problems.
2. Write an attention-grabbing opening for a presentation on "Cyber safety for college students".
3. Suggest three polite phrases for disagreeing in a group discussion.
4. Use the STAR method to answer: "Tell me about a time you worked in a team to meet a deadline."
5. Redesign this slide title to state a point: "Survey Results".